

Gnumeric

Gnumeric is a spreadsheet programme that was initially developed as an alternative to Microsoft Excel and other commercial spreadsheet applications. It was then incorporated into the Gnome desktop, as part of the Gnome office suite. Those used to advanced functions in Excel will not find the same number of features in Gnumeric, or the same behaviour in many cases. For example, selecting a column and running a find and replace operation will replace all the instances of that word or figure in the spreadsheet in Gnumeric rather than just the column selected in Excel. There is no support for Pivot tables either. Apart from these few differences, Gnumeric is functional, and we like the way it handles charts. It is a well designed spreadsheet application, and is also available for Windows. It's a lot smoother than IBM's Lotus Symphony, or OpenOffice.org's Calc. Here are some tricks to help you on your way, if you are willing to experiment with an open source alternative to Excel.

Understanding spreadsheet terminology

A programme that works with rows and columns of data, is known as a "spreadsheet". A new document, by default, has three worksheets, which are effectively three "pages". The collection of all horizontal fields in the same line are called



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"rows", and vertical fields up and down in the same line are called "columns". Each field, or intersection of a column and a row is known as a "cell". A "command" is an operation on a cell, or a collection of cells.

Increase the number of Undo operations

Gnumeric allows a default of 50 undo operations. If you are an advanced user, working on a machine with limited resources, this can reduce the amount of resources available for other applications, and for Gnumeric itself, particularly if you are going to be working with a lot of charts. Fifty undo operations is far more than is necessary for run of the mill work, and if you are going that far back into history, chances are that

you are doing something terribly wrong to begin with. Reducing the number of undo operations to about 20, or even 15, significantly improves the smoothness of your work, and does not take up unnecessary memory.

Understanding scientific number notations

One of the nifty features of Gnumeric is that the size of a cell expands to allow for up to 21 numerals. If the length of a number string exceeds 21 numerals, then the number is displayed in scientific notation. This is a convenient format to handle and make sense of really long numbers! If the calculation draws up a figure that looks something

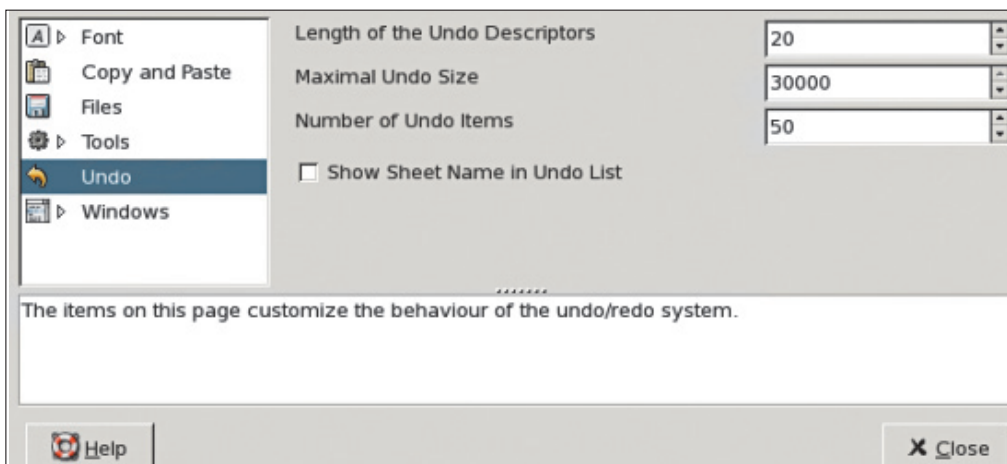
similar to "1.243E+16", it simply means that the number is 1.243×10^{16} . By default, Gnumeric spreads the width of the cell to support an accuracy of fifteen decimal spaces, which is sufficient even for rocket science. Manually dragging and reducing the width of the cell, reduces the number of decimal places displayed. Increasing the width of the cell, does not however, increase the number of decimal places displayed beyond the maximum of 15.

Make numbers behave like data

Gnumeric, like most spreadsheet applications, makes numbers behave in a certain way, and text strings behave in a certain way. Text strings are aligned to the left of the cell, and numeric strings are aligned to the right of the cell, which is just one superficial difference in the way Gnumeric displays data. Sometimes, it is necessary for users to make numeric strings behave like text strings. To do this, append (') before the number. For example, entering ('43) in a field will align the number to the left, whereas (43) will align it to the right. Once the numeral is entered with the (') before it, and the cursor is moved to another field, the (') won't show up before the number in the spreadsheet. Note that mathematical operations on such numbers will still work.

Changing the date format

By default, Gnumeric follows the American convention of displaying dates. This follows the mm/dd/yy format, instead of the dd/mm/yy format which is more common here and makes more mathematical sense. The can be problematic in the way Gnumeric handles data. To fix this, select the Date column by clicking on the column header (or the row header if you work that way). The Row and Column headers are the identifying blocks along the sides of the sheet, with the column headers being capital letters, and the row headers being numbers. Once a header is clicked, the entire column



Changing the number of default undo operations.